

Welcome to the Neighborhood!

How can we help new friends get to know our community?

Grade

K-2

Subjects

Social Studies

Estimated Duration

14-20 instructional
hours

Key Content

maps, direction,
geography,
community,
neighborhood,
descriptive writing



Students create a newcomer's guide to important places in the neighborhood around the school or in their broader community. After creating a shared class map, teams create maps documenting a specific area or community feature. With teacher support, students individually write and illustrate a description of one of the recommended places for inclusion in the guide.

Project Path

Project Launch

What are the places in our community, and what is it like being a newcomer here?

Entry event: Examine photos of familiar places in the school community and explore the experiences of newcomers.

Build Knowledge and Develop & Critique

How can we show newcomers where to find the places we recommend?

Create a class map of the community.

Form teams to create & refine group maps showing the locations of community places to recommend to newcomers.

What else do newcomers need to know about the places we recommend?

Write descriptions of select places on the maps and bring the descriptions and maps together to create a newcomer's guide.

What places can be found in a community?

Explore and learn about the neighborhood and various kinds of communities.

How can we locate places in our community?

Practice using relative and absolute location vocabulary to describe location or direction on a map; read and use maps to show the location of places in the community.

Present Products

How can we share our guide with new families in our community?

Celebrate students' work by hosting a welcome reception and sharing the guide with community newcomers.

Make It Yours

Reflect on your students

- How will you be mindful of your students' families' home languages, cultures, schedules, and available resources as you plan for school-home connections?
- What experience or knowledge do students already have about their neighborhoods, community, or maps?
- How many of your students have experienced being newcomers in a place? How can you leverage this experience while helping other students develop empathy for these challenges?
- Are there multiple languages spoken in your classroom and school community? If so, are there opportunities to leverage these language skills within the guides students develop?

- What types of features do you anticipate students will be most excited about including on their maps? How can you build on this excitement?

Reflect on your context

- Who are the newcomers in your community? How can you help students learn more about their needs?
- What community or family support might you need to leverage in order to help students safely explore neighborhoods in the community?
- How might you structure a class field trip in order to help students make experiential observations about the community?
- Are there local organizations (such as a chamber of commerce, immigrant services organization, or recreation department) that might serve as community partners or help locate a public audience for this work?
- Do students come from different communities or neighborhoods? If so, how will you structure this project?
- What will be the boundaries of the community/neighborhood addressed in your students' map and/or guide? Is the area safe to take a class walking tour? If not, how will you ensure that all students have a shared context/understanding of key landmarks in the neighborhood?

Reflect on the content & skills

- How will you support students in connecting the abstract representations of a map to their direct experience of their physical surroundings?
- How might you help students understand the differences among cardinal directions (N, S, E, W), landmarks, and relative directions (right, left, up, down)?
- What types of models and examples might be most helpful to students as they develop the community guide and their maps?

Take It Further

Here are some ideas for expanding this project if you choose to do so:

- Have staff members who are new to the school community offer their insights on the newcomer experience and serve as resources, as well as provide feedback or answer questions about newcomer needs throughout the project.
- To provide students with additional information, include materials from your social studies curriculum around community, neighborhoods, maps, etc.
- Have students talk with community members who are new to the community to connect and empathize with what it's like to be new and establish the purpose behind the project. Resident experts (<https://my.pblworks.org/resource/working-outside-experts>) on the newcomer experience might include students who are new to the school, their family members, new staff members. Students should prepare questions to ask (<https://my.pblworks.org/resource/preparing-interviews>) ahead of time and share these with the guests so that they know what to expect and understand how their visit helps support the project.
- As students explore the concept of community, encourage their creativity by offering a “construction zone” station where they can use legos, building blocks, or recyclable materials to create buildings and other items found in communities.
- As an alternative to - or extension of - a neighborhood walking tour, engage students in a read aloud and discussion of the book On the Town: A Community Adventure (https://books.google.com/books/about/On_the_Town.html?id=po6rjF-yatOC) by Judith Caseley.
- Use the book This Is How We Do It (https://books.google.com/books/about/This_is_how_We_Do_it.html?id=eGROyQEACAAJ) by Matt Lamothe to explore communities around the world. As students learn about life for children in Japan, Peru, Iran, Russia, India, Italy, and Uganda, help them build their schema about what life is like outside of their own communities. Highlight similarities and differences by showing the pages with “This is how I go to school,” which could lead to a useful discussion about community.
- Invite a newcomer (or person in your community who has lived somewhere else) to speak with the class about places the person visited in their previous community. Ask the visitor to bring photos or create a brief slideshow to help students visualize the guest's former community, which could be especially beneficial if the visitor is from a different type of community than the school's.

- Set up a video chat or virtual tour with the class in another community that is notably different from your own.
- Invite someone who works with maps to visit the classroom. Ask the guest to bring in some of the maps used in their work so that students can see how those maps may differ from the ones used for personal purposes.
- As a STEM extension, provide materials and guidance for teams to make their own functioning compass (<https://www.giftofcuriosity.com/how-to-make-a-compass/>).
- Though this project focuses on the community around the school, look at maps on a larger scale. If you are in an urban environment, show maps with geographic features such as mountains, lakes, or even farms to help students think about different locations. Conversely, if you are in a rural community, remember that students may not be as familiar with concepts such as corner markets or public transportation such as trolleys or light rail systems. Broaden students' knowledge of the world outside their community to better understand the places from which the newcomers previously came.
- To illustrate the difference between physical and political maps, use this basic physical map (<https://www.nationalgeographic.org/activity/mapping-landforms/#landforms>) from National Geographic, which has labeled landforms and bodies of water. Use this lesson (<https://www.nationalgeographic.org/activity/land-water-and-animals-map/>) to establish how maps are set up to show land and water features.
- As students are deciding which places to recommend to newcomers, invite an adult guest who has children and an adult who does not. Note that these adults are likely to be familiar with some of the same places but will certainly have some different suggestions as well; this could lead to interesting discussions and help the class to think of a wider variety of places to add to the guide.
- For a three-dimensional/tactile version of the community mapping activity, lay the butcher paper map down on the floor and have students physically place buildings and other locations on the map. Tape the pictures of each place to small blocks or boxes for students to place on the map.
- Involve students in helping determine how to present the guide and share it with newcomers in the community.
- Ask newcomers or even a guest from the Chamber of Commerce or other local organization about the most helpful way to share the guide publicly.
- To broaden your audience and find newcomers who do not have students at your school site, reach out to local apartment complex management companies, real estate agents, the immigrant services department, and so on.
- Have students share about their place during the welcome reception. Use the PBLWorks K–2 Presentation Rubric

(https://my.pblworks.org/resource/document/k_2_presentation_rubric) to help guide students as they practice talking to an audience, allowing for reflection and goal setting, and to assess their presentation as well.

- Record student recommendations on audio or video, using an app such as [Flipgrid](https://info.flipgrid.com/) (<https://info.flipgrid.com/>) or [Seesaw](https://web.seesaw.me/) (<https://web.seesaw.me/>) to collect all of the recommendations in one place. [Generate a QR code](https://www.the-qrcode-generator.com/) (<https://www.the-qrcode-generator.com/>) for each recorded description and place it next to the student's artwork on the group map.
- Create an online version of the newcomer guide using Google [Sites](https://gsuite.google.com/products/sites/) (<https://gsuite.google.com/products/sites/>) or something more kid-friendly such as [Weebly](https://www.weebly.com/) (<https://www.weebly.com/>). Include a [Google MyMaps](https://www.google.com/maps/about/mymaps/) (<https://www.google.com/maps/about/mymaps/>) of the places highlighted in the guide to make it easier for families to reference.

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Thank you to Erin Gannon and Honor Moorman for development of this project.